

broken down into an itemized list on your bill, so you can see exactly what was done and how much it cost. If something doesn't look right to you, don't be afraid to call and have the hospital clarify.

On the other hand, if you're charged for something that you consider a mistake, call to see if you can get a discount or have the charge completely waived. We actually had an emergency room fiasco a few years ago where I was *not* admitted because they didn't think my eye issues were that serious, when actually they were, as determined by the ophthalmologist I saw the following day.

I was able to get my \$100 emergency room fee waived because I wrote a letter signed by my eye doctor to the hospital, explaining the situation and that I shouldn't be held responsible for the fee. It took a few months of phone calls and haggling, but I eventually got the entire fee waived.

READER TIP:

You need to do your due diligence upfront. Find out what your insurance will and will not cover first (do you have an 80/20 plan or will your insurance cover 100% after the deductible is met) and find out what your doctor's policies are. Does your doctor require an upfront payment of your deductible or if you're having a baby, can you pay after you deliver? Make sure you know the answers to these questions as early as possible to avoid a huge and unexpected upfront payment.

—Jessi, TheBudgetMama.com

5. DON'T PAY THE ENTIRE BILL UPFRONT

Despite how good it normally is to pay your bills upfront and on time, it's not always that way when it comes to the hospital, especially if you have a deductible you have to meet first. With my biopsy, the hospital wanted me to pay for the entire procedure before it was done, but I knew my previous